Saving the planet

As Lovelock elaborated on the theme, the scientific establishment gradually began to accept the Gaia hypothesis. In the 1980s, a series of “Gaia conferences” attracted scientists from many different disciplines, willing to explore the mechanisms involved in regulating Earth’s environment to achieve homeostasis. Later, more attention was devoted to looking at the implications of the hypothesis in the face of climate change. Human activity had been shown to disturb Gaia’s system, but the issue was now whether its regulatory mechanisms could withstand further pressure—or whether Earth was facing another irreversible tipping point.

Environmentalists, who had been among the first to embrace Gaia, reacted with dismay to the theory that the human species may precipitate a catastrophic change in Earth’s equilibrium. The rallying cry of Green activists became “Save the planet!” but this was at odds with the fundamental idea of Gaia. Although the destruction of natural habitats, excessive burning of fossil fuels, depletion of biodiversity, and other human-made threats were likely to have severe consequences for many species—including humans—the planet, according to the Gaia hypothesis, will survive and find a new equilibrium. This hypothesis continues to attract criticism and be debated today.